UPFRONT

GLASSHOUSE: RAM VS SHIV VS RAVAN *PG 10*

ECOWATCH: INDIAN BIG CATS BEAT ODDS *PG 11*

> **“Unfortunately, we (Starlink) are being blocked by certain oligarchs in order to maintain their monopolistic chokehold on the Indian people”**
>
> **ELON MUSK**
> *SpaceX CEO on X, Oct. 7*



SPACE AND STRATEGY Elon Musk meets PM Narendra Modi, Washington DC, Feb. 13, 2025

▶ SATELLITE INTERNET

THE STARLINK STANDOFF

As Elon Musk alleges that vested interests are blocking Starlink’s India entry, the government insists its security rules apply equally to all operators

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

ON OCTOBER 7, ELON MUSK, the billionaire tech entrepreneur who runs SpaceX, accused “certain oligarchs” of blocking Starlink, his company’s satellite internet service, “in order to maintain their monopolistic chokehold on the Indian people”. “This is a crime against the people of India!” he wrote on X, in the same response to a user who said 11,256 Indian villages still lacked 4G coverage. Starlink uses a constellation of Low Earth Orbit (LEO) satellites to deliver internet connectivity, including to areas where mobile networks and fibreoptic cables struggle to reach. The next day, Musk was more direct. Starlink, he wrote, was licensed in more than 165 countries and had spent five years complying with “every single law and requirement” of the Indian government. “Is Ambani the real boss of India?” he asked, referring to Mukesh Ambani, CMD of Reliance Industries, which owns telecom operator Reliance Jio.

New Delhi was quick to respond. In a statement on October 8, the ministry of communications called suggestions that India’s satellite communications (satcom) framework was discriminatory “baseless and misconceived”. Communications minister Jyotiraditya Scindia subsequently said that “India does not allow a monopoly in any sector”. Junior minister Chandra S. Pemmasani explained that Starlink’s file was with the ministry of home